1990s

An upturn in India-Canada relations, especially in trade, ensues after economic liberalisation. But India's 1998 nuclear tests in Pokhran see ties deteriorate again amidst Western sanctions. Canadian foreign minister Mitchell Sharp declares, "Trust between the two countries is gone."



2006-2015

India-Canada ties improve during the tenure of Conservative PM Stephen Harper, who visits India in 2009 and 2014. India-US nuclear deal of 2005 paves the way for the **India-Canada civil nuclear cooperation agreement in 2010.** PM Modi visits Canada in 2015 as ties improve. In 2018, the two countries sign a commercial contract for Canada to supply uranium for India's power reactors.

2018

Canadian **PM Justin Trudeau's first trip to India** turns out to be a diplomatic disaster when the Canadian high commission invites Jaspal Atwal—convicted for attempting to murder an Indian cabinet minister in 1986—to an official dinner being hosted by Trudeau in Delhi. The invite is rescinded after it causes a furore. Trudeau continues to cite 'freedom of expression' at India's concerns over increasing Khalistani activism.

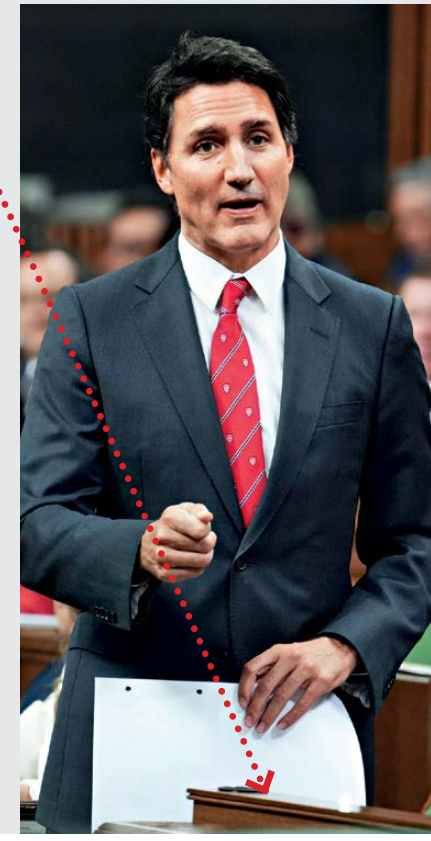




AFP

2023

On September 18, a diplomatic bombshell exploded after **PM Trudeau, speaking in Canada's parliament**, accuses agents of the Indian government of being linked with the June murder of Khalistani activist Hardeep Sing Nijjar. Canada expels an Indian intelligence agent. India denies the charges, calling them 'absurd', expels a Canadian diplomat. Ties reach a nadir.



AP

MANY SPY A US HAND IN THE EVENTS, TO BRING INDIA DOWN A FEW NOTCHES AFTER ITS G20 ASSERTIVENESS

Blame it on historical and political reasons. Historically, Canada has had a liberal immigration policy, including granting refuge to asylum-seekers, becoming in the process home to a diverse immigrant population, with India heading the list. The Indian diaspora in Canada is now estimated to be 1.85 million, with Sikhs numbering around 800,000. Barely 5,000-6,000 of these are active supporters of Khalistan. In fact, relations with Canada had nosedived when the then Liberal Party premier Pierre Trudeau, father of the current incumbent, turned down requests by his Indian counterpart Indira Gandhi in the early 1980s to extradite Khalistan extremist Talwinder Singh Parmar, who had taken shelter in Canada. Parmar would later go on to mastermind the Kanishka bombing of 1985, the mid-air explosion of the Air India